CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Tuesday, October 27, 2026

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RE: Woodside exits Greater Sunrise, China tipped to step in · Fiji constitution bill closes consultation within a week · Vanuatu opens UNCLOS case against France · Albanese pledges duress alarms for MPs · US commits $44m to Pacific crime fight

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,850	0.7029	13,680	0.5693
+0.38%	+0.31%	+0.21%	+0.26%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Woodside is exiting the Greater Sunrise gas project in Timor-Leste, with the ABC reporting China is positioned to step forward in its place.
2. Fiji's public consultation on the Constitution Amendment Bill closes within a week, with coalition partner SODELPA now demanding full repeal of the 2013 constitution rather than amendment, as Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka's term runs down.
3. Anthony Albanese has pledged duress alarms and an accelerated security review for federal MPs after last week's attack on independent Helen Haines, as a new AI moderation tool found almost half of nearly 460,000 comments on 22 Labor MPs' social media accounts were abusive.

TOP STORIES

CHINA-PACIFIC

China tipped to step forward as Woodside exits Timor-Leste gas project

Woodside is withdrawing from the Greater Sunrise gas project in Timor-Leste, and the ABC reports China is tipped to "step forward" in Woodside's place. The exit follows Dili's October 23 security and regional-priorities talks with Canberra, and a same-day Islands Business bulletin quotes Deputy Prime Minister **Richard Marles** describing Timor-Leste as key to Australia's regional security network.

per ABC News: "China tipped to 'step forward' as Woodside exits Timor-Leste gas project"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji's constitutional reform clock runs down to a week

One week of public consultation remains on the bill to amend Fiji's 2013 constitution, a reform **Sitiveni Rabuka** promised on taking office in 2022, with elections four months away. Analyst Jope Tarai said the prime minister wants reform within his term, "but whether that is possible is diminishing as we speak." Coalition partner SODELPA has rejected Bill 32 outright and demanded full repeal of the 2013 document, per an Islands Business PACNEWS bulletin.

per ABC Pacific: "Fiji PM running out of time to pass constitutional reform bill"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Vanuatu opens UNCLOS arbitration against France

Vanuatu has opened arbitration against France under the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea over how Paris classifies islands it administers in the region, the ABC reported. The filing takes a territorial and maritime-entitlement dispute with a metropolitan Pacific power into international arbitration; the broadcast did not detail the specific islands or claims at issue.

per ABC Pacific: "Vanuatu begins UNCLOS arbitration against France over island classification"

AU-POLITICS

Albanese confirms bolstered MP security after Haines attack

Anthony Albanese told caucus the government will accelerate its existing review of MP safety after last week's attack on independent **Helen Haines**, calling it a turning point. Security upgrades to MPs' homes and faster office upgrades are on the table, and MPs are expected to be offered portable duress alarms, the Sydney Morning Herald and Politico reported.

per SMH Federal Politics (Natassia Chrysanthos): "Albanese confirms bolstered security for MPs after Haines attack" · also Politico

OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

AI-driven cyberattacks surge, superannuation in firing line · SMH Federal Politics

Australia's cyber intelligence agency has recorded an *80 percent* surge in attacks as criminals and foreign governments deploy new AI models against Australian targets, including superannuation savings, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. **Richard Marles** said there had been a "significant increase" in malicious AI activity targeting organisations.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Gaza war cemetery FOI emails withheld for months · Crikey

Officials withheld correspondence on the destruction of an Australian war cemetery in Gaza for months, calling the freedom-of-information request "complex," Crikey reported. Most of the material eventually released had already been quoted in Senate estimates.

AU-POLITICS

UN presses parliament after shackling bills blocked · ABC News

United Nations experts issued a statement urging the Australian parliament to progress reforms for women and children in custody, after legislation addressing shackling and strip searching was blocked, the ABC reported.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Business groups answer Chalmers' call on spending cuts · The Australian

Business leaders have put forward a wishlist of savings after Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** challenged critics to say what they would cut, The Australian reported, alongside the Coalition's costings for more than *$30 billion* in proposed savings.

AU-DEFENSE

Spy agencies join early warning system for AI threats · ABC Politics

Australia's signals intelligence agency is part of an "early warning" system designed to detect incoming AI-driven cyberattacks, the ABC reported, amid a broader rise in AI-enabled hacking attempts against government and industry targets.

STAT OF THE DAY

$44M

US funding pledged to counter Pacific transnational crime

Washington's commitment, reported in today's Islands Business bulletin, underscores accelerating US engagement as Washington and Beijing compete for Pacific security partnerships.

Islands Business

PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Twelve dead in Kimbe after armed robbery ends in police gunfight

Police said 13 armed men robbed a store in Kimbe, West New Britain Province's main town, and 12 died when their getaway vehicle rolled and a shootout with police followed, the ABC reported. A major investigation is under way.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Manus Province readies 80,000 filter kits as water supply dwindles

Manus Province is preparing *80,000* water filter kits as supplies dwindle, the ABC reported, without further detail on the cause of the shortage or the distribution timeline.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Bougainville landowners to decide next phase of Kongara exploration

Landowners in Central Bougainville will decide whether mineral exploration advances beyond initial drilling at the EL02 site, the Autonomous Region's president said, according to Islands Business.

TOKELAU · RNZ PACIFIC

New tide gauges strengthen Tokelau's meteorological capacity

New tide gauges installed across Tokelau's three atolls will strengthen the territory's meteorological systems, RNZ Pacific reported. Tokelau Meteorological Services director Asifangalua Pasilio said the territory currently relies on Fiji and Samoa for tide predictions, calling the stations "a part of a longer journey of building Tokelau's own meteorology capability."

TONGA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tonga urges SPC members to ensure decisions deliver for Pacific people

Tonga urged members of the Pacific Community to ensure governance decisions deliver tangible benefits for Pacific people, according to an Islands Business PACNEWS bulletin, as the regional science and development body approaches its 80th anniversary.

TIMOR-LESTE · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Marles calls Timor-Leste key to Australia's regional security network

Deputy Prime Minister **Richard Marles** called Timor-Leste key to Australia's regional security network, according to an Islands Business PACNEWS bulletin, days after Canberra and Dili advanced security and regional-priorities talks on October 23.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

US commits more than $44 million to combat Pacific transnational crime

Washington has committed *more than $44 million* to counter transnational crime across the Pacific, Islands Business reported, alongside a separate US-Fiji partnership announced in the same bulletin to strengthen disease detection.

FIJI · AFP

Fiji islanders brave rising seas to protect waterfront homes

Residents on Fiji's small islands are building sea walls and raising floors to protect waterfront properties they value at "US$100 million views," as rising seas erode shorelines, AFP reported via the South China Morning Post.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC

Parties set out Pasifika positions as NZ advance voting opens

RNZ Pacific asked New Zealand's main political parties, including ACT, the Greens, Labour, National and NZ First, where they stand on Pasifika issues ahead of the country's November 7 general election, for which early voting opened this week. ACT said it would cut government spending and lower the carbon tax, while the Greens pledged to cut household costs, including power bills and public transport fares.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · CANBERRA TIMES

Kennedy warns estimates attacks on public servants are an OH&S risk

Treasury Secretary **Steven Kennedy** warned Senate estimates that hostile questioning of public servants constitutes a workplace health and safety risk, defending a push to restrict how estimates footage is used, the Canberra Times reported.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Payman invokes Haines attack in bitter staffing row

Independent Senator **Fatima Payman** invoked last week's attack on fellow independent **Helen Haines** while pressing Senator **Don Farrell** on why she has been denied extra staff two years after requesting an adviser, in a late-night Senate estimates exchange. Farrell called the remarks "outrageous" and asked her to withdraw them.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

PM's office dumps KPMG as auditor

The Prime Minister's office has dropped KPMG as its auditor, citing "differences in quality" and unspecified conduct concerns, The Australian reported.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Human rights commissioners billed taxpayers for estimates coaching

The Australian Human Rights Commission paid for a communications consultant to coach commissioners on answering Senate estimates questions, The Australian reported, drawing criticism over the use of taxpayer funds for media training.

AU-POLITICS · SMH

Albanese admits sewage claim for $6 million grant was wrong

Anthony Albanese admitted a $6 million grant for Marrickville Golf Club was not, as he had said, intended to fix a sewerage problem, after bureaucrats told Senate estimates the funding was never designed for that purpose, the Sydney Morning Herald reported.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

AI tool flags almost half of comments on Labor MPs' pages as abusive

A new AI moderation tool trialled on the social media accounts of 22 Labor MPs and senators flagged *almost half* of 460,000 comments as abusive between July and October, including 2,497 threats and 2,487 comments using violent language, the ABC reported. MPs are demanding platforms take greater responsibility for the abuse.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · AU MINISTERIAL

More investment, more jobs for Australia's critical minerals future

Trade Minister **Don Farrell** announced new investment and jobs commitments for Australia's critical minerals sector, according to a government media release, which did not detail specific dollar figures in the text provided.

READOUT · AU MINISTERIAL

Biggest ever prospectus showcases Australia's critical minerals potential

The government released what it called Australia's biggest-ever critical minerals prospectus, a showcase document aimed at attracting new investment, per a trade ministry release.

UPCOMING

OCT 29

Deadline for PNG public servants to resign under conflict rules

Tests enforcement of integrity rules in Port Moresby at a moment of heightened scrutiny of provincial and national governance.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues, shaping Wellington's defence spending trajectory and China policy.

NOV 2026

Fiji constitution amendment bill consultation period closes

Determines whether Rabuka can bank his signature reform before an election expected within months.

FEB
2027

Fiji general election

Sets the deadline pressure behind the current constitutional reform push and coalition tensions over Bill 32.

THE WIRE

TRADE-ECONOMY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Solomon Islands LDC graduation: what will actually change?

Solomon Islands is due to graduate from least-developed-country status in 2027, and Devpolicy's Lloyd Loji argues the real risks of the transition lie not in aid and trade access, which may change less than feared, but elsewhere.

ASPI STRATEGIST

To secure supply, Australia needs to engage with Africa's mineral sovereignty

ASPI's Strategist frames Africa's push for greater control over its own minerals as a national security question for Australia, not just a commercial one for miners, urging Canberra to coordinate directly with African governments.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Australia should do more to back Japan and the ICC in the face of US sanctions

The United States is sanctioning the International Criminal Court and its Japanese president, and the Lowy Interpreter argues Australia has offered little beyond private words, pressing Canberra to do more to back Japan and the court.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

Pause the disposal of Victoria Barracks Sydney

ASPI's Strategist argues the government should pause the disposal of Victoria Barracks Sydney, saying outstanding questions about the historic site need resolution "before the process has gone too far for reversal."

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

Beyond the Pukpuk Treaty, Australia's Strategic Footprint in PNG Grows

The piece describes continuing defence cooperation between Australia and Papua New Guinea following the Pukpuk Treaty, noting planned new rotations, infrastructure investment, and expanded recruitment of Papua New Guineans into the Australian Defence Force.

Argument: Australia's security engagement with Papua New Guinea continues deepening beyond the Pukpuk Treaty, with new troop rotations planned, defence infrastructure investment, and expanded ADF recruitment.

THE DIPLOMAT

The 2026 US Midterm Elections: Ramifications for Australia

The Diplomat argues that from AUKUS to trade, the implications of the US midterms for Australia are particularly profound, though the available summary does not detail specific mechanisms.

> **Argument:** The outcome of the 2026 US midterm elections carries profound implications for Australia across AUKUS and trade.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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